



Scrye Companion Setup

Putting Tailscale between your PC and your phone, step
by step.

For everyone · last updated 2026-08-02

The companion server binds to `127.0.0.1` and nothing else. That is intentional: it is a socket that can send commands into a live MUD session and read private tells, so it should not appear on a café Wi-Fi because a default was permissive.

To use it from a phone, put **Tailscale** between the two devices. Tailscale gives your PC a private address only your own devices can reach, plus a real Let's Encrypt certificate on a name like `desktop-abc.tail1234.ts.net` — and it **renews that certificate itself**.

That last part is the reason this route is recommended over `tailscale cert`, which hands you certificate files to install manually. Let's Encrypt certificates expire after 90 days, and a manually installed one would stop your phone working on a day you had forgotten all about it.

What you end up with

```
phone —HTTPS/WSS→ desktop-abc.tail1234.ts.net:443 (Tailscale's proxy, holds the TLS cert)
                        |
                        ▼ plain HTTP, never leaves the machine
                    127.0.0.1:4747 (Scrye's companion server)
```

Scrye itself stays loopback-bound and learns nothing about certificates.

1. Install Tailscale on the PC

Download from <https://tailscale.com/download> and install. Sign in with whichever account you prefer — Google, Microsoft, GitHub. The free plan covers personal use comfortably.

Confirm it is up:

```
& "C:\Program Files\Tailscale\tailscale.exe" status
```

The Windows installer does not add `tailscale` to `PATH`, so use the full path (or add it yourself). The first line of output is this machine.

2. Install Tailscale on the phone

App Store or Play Store, then **sign in with the same account**. Same account means same tailnet means the two devices can see each other.

Then **switch it on**. On iOS Tailscale is a VPN profile, and installing plus signing in does not connect it — the toggle in the app does. A phone that is signed in but toggled off shows as `offline` in `tailscale status` on the PC, and the `.ts.net` URL simply will not resolve, which looks exactly like a broken server.

Check the PC appears in the phone's device list, and that `tailscale status` on the PC does *not* say the phone is offline, before continuing.

3. Start Scrye's companion server

In Scrye, in any connected world:

```
.companion
```

It prints the loopback URL, the token, and this world's `sessionId`. Then:

```
.companion tailscale
```

It prints your machine's tailnet name, the URL your phone will use, and the exact proxy command for step 4. If it says Tailscale is not installed or not running, fix that first — Scrye is reading the real state, not guessing.

4. Put Tailscale's TLS proxy in front

In a terminal on the PC:

```
& "C:\Program Files\Tailscale\tailscale.exe" serve --bg --https=443 http://127.0.0.1:4747
```

The first run will not succeed. Serve has to be enabled on the tailnet once, so the command prints a URL and stops:

```
Serve is not enabled on your tailnet.  
To enable, visit:  
https://login.tailscale.com/f/serve?node=...
```

Open that URL, approve, then **run the same command again** — it completes silently the second time. Approving also enables HTTPS certificates, which publishes your machine names to a public certificate transparency ledger; that is inherent to Let's Encrypt rather than something Tailscale adds.

Check it took:

```
& "C:\Program Files\Tailscale\tailscale.exe" serve status
```

`--bg` keeps it running in the background; it survives reboots. To stop proxying:

```
& "C:\Program Files\Tailscale\tailscale.exe" serve --https=443 http://127.0.0.1:4747 off
```

5. Open it on the phone

Browse to the URL from step 3 — `https://desktop-abc.tail1234.ts.net/` — paste the token, connect, pick your session, subscribe.

A real certificate means **no browser warning**, and more importantly a genuine *secure context*, which is what a service worker needs. That is the whole reason this step exists before the installable PWA (design §7.1, §8.1).

Troubleshooting

The CLI says "Logged out" even though a browser said login succeeded. A command that merely *triggers* a login (like `serve`) prints a URL and exits immediately, so nothing is waiting to consume the result. Use `tailscale up` instead — it blocks until the login actually completes — and let it return on its own rather than closing the window. If that still fails, check the Tailscale tray app is running at all (on Windows the GUI and the background service are separate), and try an elevated PowerShell.

Logged in but the admin console shows the device grey. On Windows, *logged in* and *connected* are different states, and the console's dot also lags. `tailscale status` on the machine is authoritative; if it reports the node with a `100.x.x.x` address, you are fine. If it says Tailscale is stopped, connect from the tray icon or run `tailscale up`.

tailscale is not recognised. The Windows installer skips `PATH`. Use the full path `C:\Program Files\Tailscale\tailscale.exe`, or add the folder to `PATH` yourself.

The phone reaches the URL but sees a Kestrel error, or nothing. The companion server is not running. Run `.companion status` in Scrye — the proxy is happy to forward to a port with nothing behind it.

Connects but immediately drops. Wrong token. Each `.companion` start mints a new one, so a token from an earlier run will not work. Re-run `.companion status` to reprint it.

The certificate consent page never appears. Some tailnets already have HTTPS enabled, in which case there is nothing to consent to. Verify with `tailscale serve status`.

Nothing resolves the `.ts.net` name. MagicDNS is off. Enable it in the admin console under DNS; `.companion tailscale` reports this case explicitly.

What this does and does not give you

Does: access from anywhere the phone has a network, a real certificate with automatic renewal, no port forwarding, no public exposure of the desktop, and no service for anyone to operate.

Does not: notifications while the Scrye page is closed. A VPN keeps the *socket* alive but the mobile OS still suspends the *app*. That needs Web Push, which the design covers in §7.2 — and notably it also needs no hosted component, because Scrye itself can be the push application server.

| A note on what comes next

`tailscale serve` adds identity headers to proxied requests, identifying which tailnet user made the request. When per-device pairing lands (design §10 step 4), that is a stronger signal than the shared token this setup uses — worth looking at before building device authentication from scratch.

Sources: [Tailscale Serve](#) · [serve CLI reference](#) · [Enabling HTTPS](#)